

**Board 1**

North Deals

None Vul

♠ A 6  
♥ J 9  
♦ 10 8 7 4 2  
♣ K J 9 3

♠ K J 10 8 4

♥ A K 3 2

♦ 9 5

♣ A 6



♠ 7 5 3  
♥ Q 10 7 6  
♦ K Q J  
♣ Q 10 8

♠ Q 9 2

♥ 8 5 4

♦ A 6 3

♣ 7 5 4 2

| West     | North | East | South |
|----------|-------|------|-------|
|          | 1 ♠   | Pass | 2 ♠   |
| Pass     | 3 ♦   | Pass | 3 ♠   |
| All Pass |       |      |       |

3 ♠ by North

**North plays 3 ♠. East leads the ♦ K.**

Losers: ♠ 1 : ♥ 2 : ♦ 1 : ♣ 1 : Total = 5

The ♦ loser, the ♣ loser and the Ace of trumps are unavoidable. One ♥ loser is also unavoidable, but the second one can be ruffed in dummy. You cannot afford to play a single trump.

Win the ♦ A and play ♥ A, ♥ K, ♥ 2. The defenders will win this. If your ♥ 3 happened to set up then you won't have to ruff it, but more than likely the ♥ s split 4-2. The defenders may now take a ♦ winner, or they may lead ♠ A and another ♠. But they cannot stop you from ruffing your fourth ♥ with dummy's ♠ Q or ♠ 9.

The defenders may not lead trumps to try to stop your ruff.

In that case you must be sure to ruff the fourth ♥ with the ♠ Q or the ♠ 9. If West wants to over-ruff it will be with the ♠ A which you must lose anyway.

Look at what would have happened if you had led a trump at trick 2. West could have won the ♠ A and played another ♠. Then, when East took the third ♥ he could lead his last ♠ and dummy would have no trump to ruff the final ♥ with.

With 6 points you must respond. And with 3 ♠ s you can support partner's suit.

You respond 2 ♠ and partner bids 3 ♦.

Partner's 3 ♦ bid is a Help Suit Game Try. He is inviting you to bid game if you have a good 2 ♠ response, particularly if you can help him in ♦ s.

Although have the ♦ help you have a bare minimum response. So you return to 3 ♠ which partner passes.

South would play 3 ♠.

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North plays 3 ♠. East leads the ♦ K.

**Board 3**

East Deals

E-W Vul

♠ 7 5  
♥ K 6 4  
♦ A Q 8 5 3  
♣ A J 2

♠ K 9 4

♥ J 9 3

♦ K 7 2

♣ Q 10 5 4

|   |   |   |
|---|---|---|
|   | N |   |
| W |   | E |
|   | S |   |

♠ A J 2

♥ A 10 7

♦ J 10 9

♣ K 7 6 3

♠ Q 10 8 6 3

♥ Q 8 5 2

♦ 6 4

♣ 9 8

| West     | North | East | South |
|----------|-------|------|-------|
|          |       | 1♣   | Pass  |
| 1♦       | Pass  | 1NT  | Pass  |
| 3NT      |       |      |       |
| All Pass |       |      |       |

3NT by East

The immediate, burning question is whether to win the first trick or not. By winning you will create a second ♠ stopper - as long as North never gets into the lead. But the problem is that your main finesse is going into North. So you hold up on the first trick, sacrificing the chance of a second stopper. When North returns a ♠ you hold up again, playing the ♠J which South wins with the ♠Q. Your ♠A is finally driven out on the third trick.

Now you take the ♦ finesse, losing to North's ♦K (as expected). But it doesn't matter because North has no more ♠s. Whatever he plays you win and take all your winners, which happen to add up to 9.

This is one of those hands where your thinking would be clearer if you had less strength.

If you did not have the ♠J you would never consider doing anything except hold up. But with it you start wondering if you can get a trick with it. Of course, as you see, the hold-up would be correct with ♠ A 3 2, and it is also correct with ♠ A J 2.

When you are dealt 13 points and only one biddable suit things are simple. After you open 1♣ partner responds 1♦. What now?

You can't support responder's suit with only 3 cards so you show your minimum by bidding 1NT. Partner bids 3NT and you naturally pass.

East plays 3NT. South leads ♠6. North plays ♠K.

**East plays 3NT. South leads ♠6. North plays ♠K.**

Winners: ♠ 1 : ♥ 2 : ♦ 1 : ♣ 2 : Total = 6

You need 3 more winners and clearly they must come from the ♦ suit. If South happens to hold the ♦K all will be well, but what about the times when North holds it?

**Board 5**

South Deals

None Vul

♠ K J 8  
 ♥ K 2  
 ♦ Q J 9 8  
 ♣ 10 8 5 3

♠ Q 5

♥ J 10 7 3

♦ K 6 5

♣ 9 6 4 2

|   |   |   |
|---|---|---|
|   | N |   |
| W |   | E |
|   | S |   |

♠ 10 9 6 4 2

♥ 8 5

♦ 10 7 2

♣ A J 7

♠ A 7 3

♥ A Q 9 6 4

♦ A 4 3

♣ K Q

| West         | North | East | South |
|--------------|-------|------|-------|
|              |       |      | 1 ♥   |
| Pass         | 2 ♥   | Pass | 4 ♥   |
| All Pass     |       |      |       |
| 4 ♥ by South |       |      |       |

With 20 points and 5-3-3-2 distribution you could correctly open 2NT.

However, many think it more important to bid a 5-card Major. In this case you decide to open 1♥. Partner responds 2♥.

Partner promised 6-10 points. With your 19 you decide to bid game.

South plays 4♥. West leads the ♦Q.

**South plays 4♥. West leads the ♦Q.**

Losers: ♠ 2 : ♥ 1 : ♦ 1 : ♣ 1 : Total = 5

One of the ♠ losers will be ruffed in dummy so you really just have to eliminate one loser.

It is very tempting to win the first trick in dummy and immediately finesse East for the ♥K. If the finesse works then all will be well, but if it fails another ♦ will knock out your ♦A. Then, when the defense gets into the lead with a ♠ or ♣ they will cash their ♦ winner.

Here is a better idea. Win the first trick in your hand with the ♦A, and immediately lead a low ♠ toward the ♠Q. If West holds the ♠K he is caught in the middle. If he ducks you play the ♠Q and don't lose any ♠s. If he goes up you can win a later trick with the ♠Q and dump dummy's ♦ loser on your ♠A.

Declarers in suit contracts tend to focus on trumps, they want to pull them right away. And for good reason, that is usually the best Plan.

But there are many situations when that is **NOT** the best plan. Perhaps because you need to ruff something in dummy, or perhaps (like this hand) because playing trumps would give the timing to the defense.

In this deal pulling trumps is secondary to finding a place for that slow ♦ loser.